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ASSISTANT SECRETARY RIDGWAY OP'ED PIECE

THE REYKJAVIK MEETING

In a series of extraordinarily productive meetings in Reykjavik, President Reagan and General Secretary Gorbachev narrowed the distance separating the U.S. and the U.S.S.R. on a number of arms control issues of vital importance to the security of both nations. Neither side had entered the negotiations expecting to conclude any major agreements. Although most Americans -- like those of us who participated -- were disappointed by the way the meeting in Reykjavik ended, we are far ahead of where we were before Reykjavik. There are genuine new opportunities for forward movement. The President has shown that he means to create such opportunities, while remaining firm on the essentials. Our task now is to continue to work with the Soviets to move forward in those areas where agreement now seems closer than ever. I would like to focus here on two elements of our agenda that have not received the attention they deserve: bilateral issues and human rights.

While most reports of the meeting have focused on arms control, there also was considerable progress in other areas on the U.S. agenda -- in particular on bilateral issues. Soviet Deputy Foreign Minister Bessmertnykh and I -- together with a group of Soviet and U.S. experts -- worked through the night from Saturday to Sunday to hammer out a detailed work program aimed at accelerating implementation of bilateral agreements reached at the Geneva summit last November. We also identified a number of new areas where bilateral contacts and cooperation could be intensified. Solving problems and cooperating to mutual benefit on these bilateral issues is a good thing in itself, and helps build the trust and confidence needed for more stable relations overall.

Since the Geneva Summit in November 1985, the Reagan administration has worked intensively with Moscow to define a mutually beneficial relationship in which a broad range of contacts with Soviets could take place. We are seeking to expand scientific and technical exchanges in a number of areas of benefit to the citizens of both nations. As we expand these exchanges, however, we insist that they be based on genuine scientific merit and that there be equal access by one side to the relevant people and institutions of the other. The areas in which we are discussing cooperation with the Soviets include space, transportation and satellite search and rescue. We are also exploring ways to bring about expanded international cooperation on fusion energy, following up on what was agreed by President Reagan and General Secretary Gorbachev in Geneva and confirmed by them in Reykjavik.

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In less than a year we have seen a significant increase in the cultural and people-to-people exchanges agreed to at Geneva. These exchanges provide Soviet citizens an alternative source of information about the United States and a direct opportunity to learn more about American politics, society and culture. In another important area, as President Reagan recently noted, exchanges of Soviet and American young people soon will be expanded. Moscow has agreed for the first time to significant exchanges involving undergraduates and high school students.

In Reykjavik, the President and all the rest of us made human rights a top agenda item. This is an area where progress can pay important dividends in building new trust between our countries, but where the Soviet record has been dismal. Emigration has plummeted to record lows and persecution of Jewish and human rights activists continues unabated. At Reykjavik we left the Soviets with no doubt that progress in human rights is a vital element in putting U.S.-Soviet relations on a sounder basis. The President gave the Soviets some very specific data on Jewish emigration and other human rights issues, and we explored ways of making discussion of these issues a recognized part of our overall dialogue.

Looking back at the meeting in Reykjavik, I am most encouraged by the constructive, action-oriented approach shown by both sides. We did not expect the Reykjavik talks to result in concrete agreements on specific issues or on dates for a future summit in the U.S. We strove, instead, to re-examine longstanding contentious issues and to identify areas of common ground and potential progress. This more limited -- more realistic -- goal was fulfilled. It now is up to both sides -- in Geneva and in future experts' meetings -- to build on the progress reached in Reykjavik.

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Drafted: EUR/SOV:FGalassi^{DF}
10/14/86 x76740

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